

The First Noble Truth of Suffering — The Three Characteristics

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Bhante's Essays · 12 min read

THE FIRST NOBLE TRUTH OF SUFFERING : ❖ DUKKHA

The Three Characteristics

❖❖❖ (tilakkhana)

QUESTIONS

What do you mean by the word, time?

What do you think it is?

When you say a person has changed, what do you mean?

Supposing you were describing the 'Human Experience',

What it is to be human

What words or phrases would you use?

Limit the choice to three main characteristics?

The Buddha taught that there were three basic characteristics of the human condition: dukkha, often translated as unsatisfactoriness or suffering; anicca, impermanence, transience, change; and anatta, not-self or insubstantiality. When he said that our condition was fundamentally unsatisfactory, he meant not only ❖ ordinary aches and pains, emotional and personal problems, and the sufferings of old age and death, he also meant it in two other respects which are, in fact, the other two characteristics of our existence, namely transience and not-self.

The third characteristic of our human condition, anatta, translated best as not-self, has to do with how we identify with the wrong things. We take on a mistaken identity. ❖ We believe ourselves to be the body and mind, the body and the ego or personality. ❖ He divided the human phenomenon into five categories, known as khandha or aggregates, or less lovingly heaps. ❖ The first heap consists of the material body and how mind experiences this; the second, all our sensations; the third, all our perceptions and thinking; the fourth, ❖ all our states of mind which have been produced by our will and are called volitional conditionings or formations. These are all our moods and emotions. The fifth is the knowing of all this, our consciousness. ❖ To understand how this is a mistaken identity it is necessary to investigate the second characteristic of the human condition which is not only applicable to all humans but to the whole of nature. This is the characteristic of change, anicca. ❖

Built into the idea of change is the concept of time. ❖ It is interesting to see how we use

this word.💎 We say we live time, or we've been bad times.💎 The underlying concept is that time is a tunnel or a container within which we live, in which we act out all our lives.💎 Time is somehow separate from us, existing apart from us.💎 Secondly, we seem to think we have some control over this called time. We often say, I lost time I'll make time. These underlying concepts that time somehow has an independent existence and that somehow we have some control over it are what we must investigate to determine the essential quality of change of which time is simply the measure.

One of the rituals in any family gathering is to bring out the photo albums with all the usual comments, delights and laughter.💎 But one of the interesting things is to observe the tense that people talk in. There I am when I was a teenager. That is me at your wedding last year.💎 You can see there is quite a confusion here between the present and the past with the in the present is confused.💎 This, this ego, this personality conceives itself as being the same whether in the past, present or indeed in the future.

However, the fact is that this is simply not true. Let us examine the human at the biological level.💎💎 The body I had as a baby is simply not the body I have now.💎 In fact it is said the body completely changes every seven years.💎 All that food and drink we have day in and day out go to fuel this process.💎 Cells duplicate and die, all to an internal pattern no doubt, a pre-set blueprint, the DNA, but none the less the cells are not so much changing

as themselves but dying while other cells take their place.💎 Even brain cells which don't actually die change completely within themselves so they cannot be called the same cells as the ones we were born with.

This is an important point to grasp.💎 By change, we don't mean that the same thing is simply changing shape.💎 A piece of clay can be moulded into a cup and then into a saucer so that we can see it is the same piece of clay.💎 But when it comes to the body cells, they reproduce and die. They are not the same cells changing shape.💎💎 This came home very strongly to me when I once went to an optician.💎 My left eye, it seems, had got a little better.💎 I was surprised by it, but the optician told me it was surprising that eyesight remained so static since the actual cornea, the large lens we look through, changes not once in seven years, nor in a year or in a month, but once in a week!💎 Yes indeed! Every week I'm looking at the world through a new cornea.💎 And I didn't know it!💎 In my blithe ignorance, I thought the body changed alright but not radically. Now I come to realize that the change is radical.💎 The body I have now is simply not the one I had seven years ago - at all!

In other words, it's the difference between an organisation saying it, meaning training and redeployment and another organisation which says it's going to meaning it sacks everyone it now employs and takes on a totally new work force! Our bodies change radically. They are changing radically even now. When we perceive this, when we realise this, this transience,

this changing nature, then we begin to understand why the body cannot be a substantial . The ancient Greeks understood this idea and the philosopher, Heraclitus, used the image of the river for life. ♦ He said no one steps in the same river twice for it is forever changing. ♦ The Buddha I'm sure would have pointed out that no one steps into the same river with the same foot for that too is ever changing. ♦ We can't say this is my body because as soon as we say this is body and thereby identify with it, define the self by it, it's gone, it's changed. It is like trying to grasp water. It just flows out of the hand.

Not realising this factor of change causes us to identify with the wrong things and this in turn is a cause of our suffering. ♦ It never occurs to a young person in any real sense that they are growing old. ♦ The first signs of wrinkles on the face, the first grey hairs are traumas. I knew I would grow old, but I didn't think it would really happen ...now. Growing old, losing one's powers, watching the changes on the skin, all cause us tremendous suffering. ♦ We identify so much with our bodies, desiring them to be as we want them to be, that we are for ever compensating for the process of change, of growing old, of decay - even to the point of cosmetic operations! ♦ And death, of course, every time we have a little brush with it, be it a near accident or a close shave or death of another, fills us with terror! ♦ Who are we when we have no body! ♦ If I am my body who am I when it dies?

The same critique can be applied to all the other four khanda, the other four categories the Buddha divided the human being into. If we observe our sensations, we see they are changing all the time. ♦ They are caused by outside stimuli or stimuli from within the mind itself. ♦ But everyone is unique, rising and passing away. ♦ Others arise that may be similar, but not the same ones, since the sensation I felt a moment ago has actually passed away.

To see this more clearly we need to return to the concept of time. Time itself doesn't exist. ♦ It is just a concept in the mind whereby we order the events that have happened to us. ♦ Ten years ago I went to my sisters wedding. Last year I visited them as usual. ♦ This year I will see them in December. ♦ Although I speak as though all this is real now, in fact, nothing's happening at all by way of my sister.

Let's say it is now 8 o'clock in the evening. ♦ 7.45 has come and gone. It no longer exists. ♦ In fact 7.49 has gone, no longer exists. It has collapsed, disappeared, vanished. ♦ It no

longer. ♦ Now 8.01 has not yet arrived. ♦ It, too, doesn't exist in any way. ♦ The only existence, the only real point that I experience in which I am actually alive is this , this very moment - 8 oclock. We live on this knife-edge of time. ♦ Awareness, what we are developing in meditation, is a faculty that can only exist in the now. ♦ We can't be aware of yesterday. Awareness does not live there. ♦ We can't be aware of tomorrow. Awareness is not born there. ♦ Awareness arises only here and now in this minute moment. ♦ Awareness

and consciousness are simply here and now and at no other time.

[illegible]

Just as this is true of our physical bodies and sensations, so it is also true of the third khanda or aggregate, our perceptions.❖ We can only perceive what there is now.❖ I can only see a cup when a cup is there and perceptions of the cup arise and pass away. These perceptions are purely mental images, words, ideas, value judgements of good or bad. They also arise and pass away.❖❖ And they never arise again, but new ones affected by new information arise.❖ So our perceptions, our ideas, our thoughts, are always changing. Again these same arguments pertain to our states of mind, the volitional conditionings, be they moods or emotions of depression, anxiety, anger or joy, happiness and peace. Whatever the state of mind, it never repeats itself.❖ So which state of mind shall I identify with?❖ Which one shall I call me or mine?❖ If I define myself in my depression - what am I when happiness arises?❖ If I say I am all my moods and emotions, then I fall into the error of believing is existing yesterday when I was depressed, now when I am angry and tomorrow when I will be happy!❖ But this is only now, and this now passes away.❖ It is delusion to identify with the past and the future.

The same is true of the final khanda or aggregate of consciousness. Often people will argue: ♦ yes I agree I am not my body or other mental factors since its all arising and passing away. ♦ I see that now. But my consciousness is steady. I am my consciousness,

my knowing of these things. However, in meditation this last hold onto our false identity begins to evaporate, for we begin to realise that there can only be consciousness when there is an object to be conscious of. ♦ If I was to enter a space with no objects at all and the mind itself produced no thinking, what would I be conscious of? ♦ Consciousness begs an object. Without an object, there is no consciousness, no knowing. ♦ Indeed there are times when we are , not conscious. ♦ If I say I am my consciousness, who am I when I'm in deep sleep or anaesthetised on the operating table, or knocked unconscious?

So here we have investigated the First Noble Truth from the point of view of the three characteristics of existence: transience (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha) and the insubstantiality or the not-self of the personality (anatta).

The Buddha, when he was enlightened, at first thought his discoveries too subtle for people to understand. ♦ But persuaded otherwise he sought out his five former companions. ♦ They'd left him a while earlier because he ate some milk rice and they thought he had given up the training of the ascetic and gone soft. ♦ But in fact this meal gave him the energy to reach full enlightenment.

When he approached them, they were reluctant at first to receive him, but as he came closer, his presence was all too powerful and they prepared a seat for him and he taught the Dhamma by way of the Four Noble Truths. At the end of this first Discourse, known as The Turning of the Wheel of the Law, one of the four, Kondanna was enlightened or, as the scripture says, 'the spotless immaculate vision of the Dhamma arose in him'. ♦ Later that same day after they had all shared the food brought in from alms round, he gave the second discourse, in which the three characteristics of existence are taught for the first time. ♦ This is how it ends.

When a wise disciple understands (that the five aggregates are transitory, unsatisfying and do not constitute a permanent self), non-attachment to the body, sensations, perceptions, emotions and consciousness arises. As non-attachment arises, sense desires and attachments fade away. ♦ With the fading away of sense desires and attachments, the heart is liberated. With liberation, the knowledge arises, .

This is the fundamental teaching of the Buddha. ♦ Through meditation and throughout our daily life, these characteristics should become more and more plain to us. ♦ Life is changing. This body, this mind is not me, not mine. ♦ Identifying with it causes me to have wrong expectations, false hopes. This wrong identification is the cause of my suffering. Not to identify with them is to lose my attachment to them, to be non-attached. These insights lead us to a proper relationship with ourselves and others and ultimately leads us to the experience which is beyond body and mind, Nibbana. ♦ We can say that the experience of Nibbana is the discovery of our true identity and it establishes a new way of relating to ourselves and the world. ♦ What is this new relationship? It is simply that since everything

arises and passes away, I do not regard it as me or mine or self. I come to realise that when I identify wrongly with all this, it is a cause of suffering.❖ I become non-attached.❖ But let me hasten to add this is not a cold detachment!❖ Far from it! Because of this perspective, 'the heart is liberated! We begin to find real wisdom and true compassion. In conclusion, the more we become aware of the transient changing, radically changing nature of our lives, the more we realise there is no stopping place, no rest, no stability, no security.❖ The more we accept these facts, the more we live within the flow of living, and work within it.❖ Through meditation, coming to terms with the ever-changing nature of our lives, we free ourselves of false fears and frustrations, fearing the loss of what we cannot actually keep, frustrated by not being able to achieve what is actually unachievable.❖ It leads to a greater realism and in that greater realism we will find the peace and joy we all so dearly seek.

May the Teachings of the Buddha shed light into your life!

May you quickly attain the Supreme Goal!

SUMMARY

ANICCA❖❖❖❖❖❖❖

ever-changing nature, transience, arising and passing away of every moment

radical change

DUKKHA

ordinary suffering and pain in life

unsatisfactory nature of living in a world that is forever changing

suffering that comes from wanting what we cannot have

from wrong identity

ANATTA

not-self, insubstantiality

not believing that my body and mind are unchanging

realising that my body and mind cannot be permanent

cannot be a 'me' or 'self'

TIME

a mental concept that helps us order events in our history, construct a future

does not actually exist in the past or the future

the only real time is NOW, the presenting moment

When we understand this, we are beginning to see our lives in a realistic way.

Meditation is a technique whereby we experience these three characteristics within ourselves.

At first, this way of thinking about ourselves seems strange, even threatening, but the Buddha said these discoveries would lead to our liberation, liberation from all suffering.

